Volunteer Welcome and First Shift

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Why this guide exists

A first shift should not depend on which coordinator happens to be working that morning. Center Valley Community Pantry is a fictional nonprofit created for an OrgFlow demonstration. This guide describes one consistent welcome experience so a new volunteer can find the right person, feel comfortable asking questions, and begin useful work safely. No real volunteers or households are represented.

Before the first shift

Jordan Lee sends the welcome email at least two days before arrival. It confirms the shift date, side entrance, parking beside the blue loading door, closed-toe shoes, and a contact for schedule changes. Volunteers can ask for accommodations privately. No health information belongs in shared scheduling files.

New volunteers arrive by 8:30 a.m. and report to the shift lead at the blue welcome table. Returning volunteers arrive at 8:45 a.m. and distribution opens at 9:00 a.m. The shift lead has the day's station assignments, an orientation checklist, and a badge with only the volunteer's preferred name.

The 15-minute orientation

The shift lead explains the pantry's approach: treat every visitor with dignity, offer meaningful choice when inventory permits, and avoid assumptions about anyone's circumstances. Show the accessible entrance, exits, handwashing sink, washrooms, first aid kit, damage-report shelf, and designated chilled storage area. Introduce the volunteer to one experienced buddy.

Only trained staff may change inventory totals or resolve eligibility questions. Volunteers should not photograph pantry visitors, discuss household records in public areas, or use personal devices to store visitor information. If a volunteer is unsure about an item, they stop and ask the shift lead.

Step-by-step first shift

1. Greet the new volunteer at the blue welcome table at 8:30 a.m.
2. Confirm their preferred name and introduce the experienced buddy.
3. Point out handwashing facilities, washrooms, first aid, and emergency exits.
4. Explain privacy, respectful language, and the no-photo rule.
5. Walk through receiving, produce, dry goods, and carrying assistance.
6. Demonstrate one assigned station and let the new volunteer practice with support.
7. Check in halfway through the shift and offer a short break.
8. At the end, ask what was unclear and record one improvement idea.

9. Offer the approved next-shift sign-up link without pressure.

If something goes wrong

A spill, damaged package, or missing chilled-storage label should be reported to Sam Rivera, Operations Manager. In a medical emergency, call emergency services and notify the shift lead. Do not make promises about replacement groceries or modify household records without authorization.

Recording completion

The shift lead records the orientation date, station, assigned buddy, and completion status in the volunteer register. Jordan reviews first-shift feedback at the monthly planning meeting. A volunteer who needs additional training is scheduled with an experienced buddy rather than assigned alone.

Ownership and related files

Jordan Lee owns this guide, with Sam Rivera as backup. Use Monthly Volunteer Scheduling, the October Availability Register, and Building Safety Notes as related sources. This guide is a source document. Any new OrgFlow procedure should be reviewed before publication.